Aluminium-Water Combustion for Zero Carbon Marine Shipping: Masters Proposal

Md Nadim Ahmed

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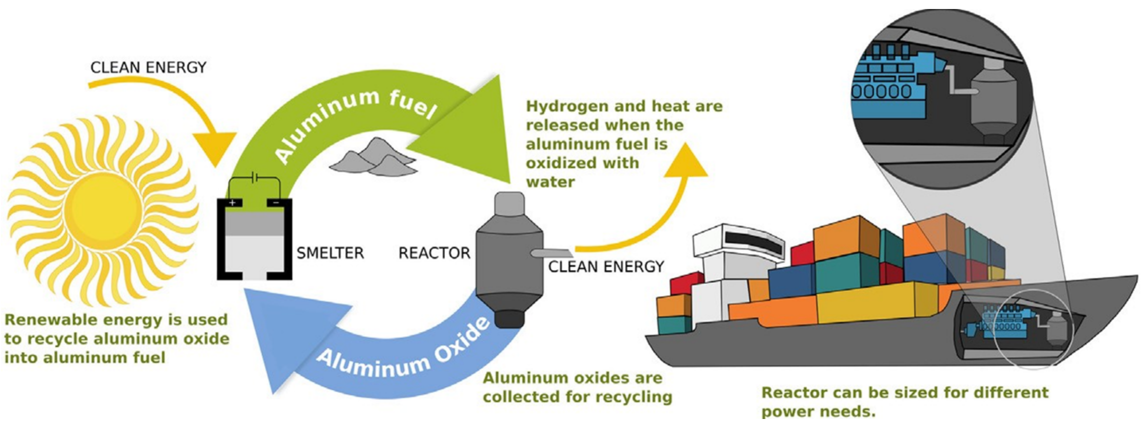

Figure 1: Aluminium powder as maritime shipping fuel (Energy Life-cycle). Adapted from [1]

Abstract

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1 Research Background

Overview

Maritime shipping plays a crucial role in global trade, facilitating around 80% of all commerce [10]. This makes it essential for globalization, economic development, and maintaining living standards. However, the sector also contributes significantly to global greenhouse gas emissions, accounting for 2-3% of global emissions and approximately 10% of all transport-related emissions [11, 10].

In response, the International Maritime Organization (IMO) has set ambitious targets to curb emissions from international shipping. By 2030, the IMO aims to reduce annual greenhouse gas emissions by 20-30% compared to 2008 levels, with a more aggressive target of 70-80% reduction by 2040 [12].

1.1 Preliminary Analysis of Electro-Fuels Options

Overview

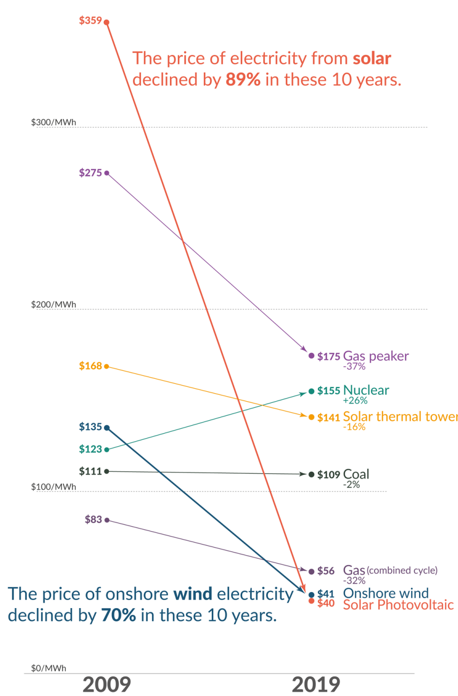

Figure 2: Falling cost of solar electricity vs Fossil Fuels [2]

Recent years have witnessed a dramatic decline in the cost of low-carbon electricity sources, particularly solar and wind power, as illustrated in Figure 2. This cost reduction has significantly enhanced the viability of transitioning to a low-carbon economy, yet substantial challenges persist in the so-called hard-to-abate sectors, among which marine shipping features prominently.

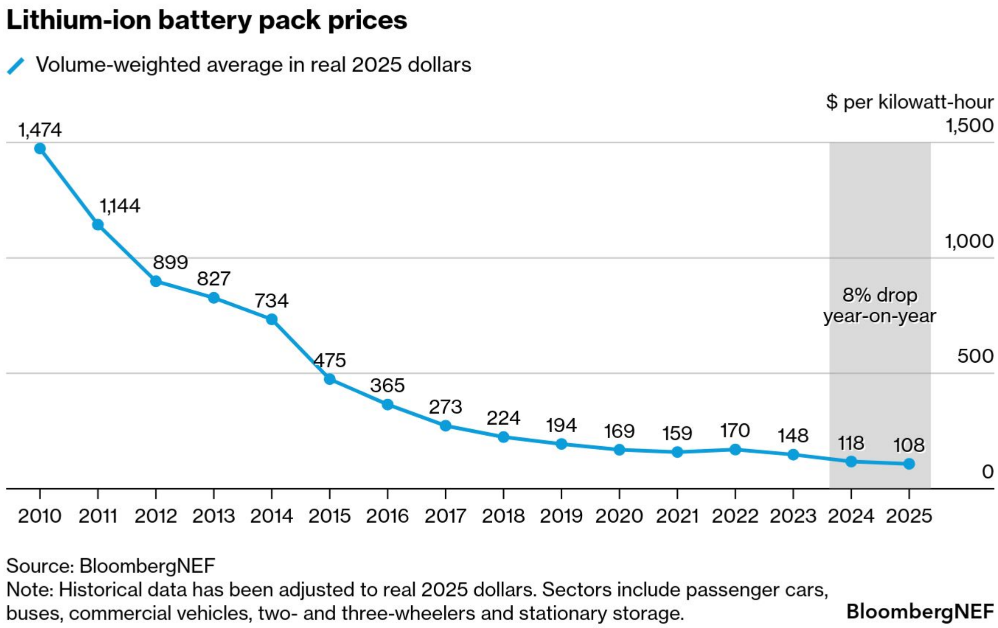

Figure 3: Falling cost of lithium ion battery packs [3]

The predominant method for storing electrical energy remains electrochemical batteries, with lithium-ion technology leading the charge. These batteries have increasingly displaced fossil fuels in passenger vehicles and, more recently, have begun penetrating short and medium-distance trucking applications [13]. This transformation has been driven largely by the precipitous decline in lithium battery prices, as demonstrated in Figure 3. The technology's reach has even extended to inland shipping routes, where standardized and swappable battery packs are being deployed in China [14]. Major battery manufacturers such as CATL are making substantial investments in these markets, signaling confidence in the technology's continued expansion [15].

However, despite remarkable advances in both price and energy density, lithium-ion batteries remain largely impractical for deep-sea shipping, which accounts for approximately 70% of marine shipping emissions [16]. The fundamental constraint lies in the current energy density limitations of lithium-ion technology, which ranges from 0.1 to 0.5 kWh/kg [17, 18]—substantially lower than gasoline, which can exceed 10 kWh/kg [9]. This considerable disparity in energy density presents a formidable barrier to the electrification of long-distance maritime transport.

In response to the energy density limitations of lithium-ion batteries, researchers and policymakers have increasingly explored the use of abundant and inexpensive solar electricity to produce alternative fuels, primarily through electrolysis. This approach has given rise to a diverse landscape of electro-fuel options, which can be systematically organized into four broad classifications:

- **Simple electro-fuels** - hydrogen and ammonia, which represent the most straightforward products of electrolytic processes

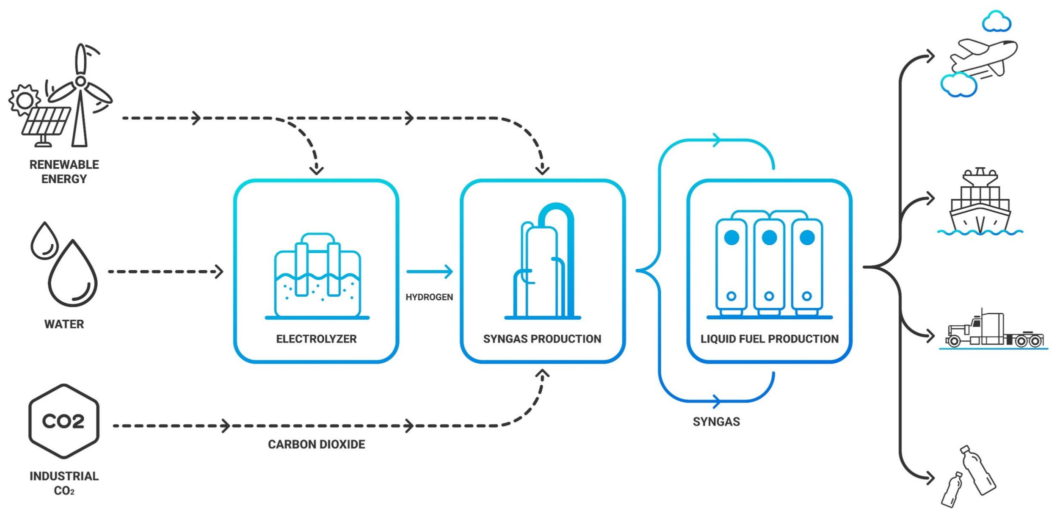

Figure 4: High Level Process Diagram for synthetic hydrocarbon production from renewable electricity [4]

- **Synthetic hydrocarbons** - primarily methane and methanol, whose production pathways are illustrated in Figure 4, which depicts the high-level process for synthesizing these fuels from low-carbon electricity

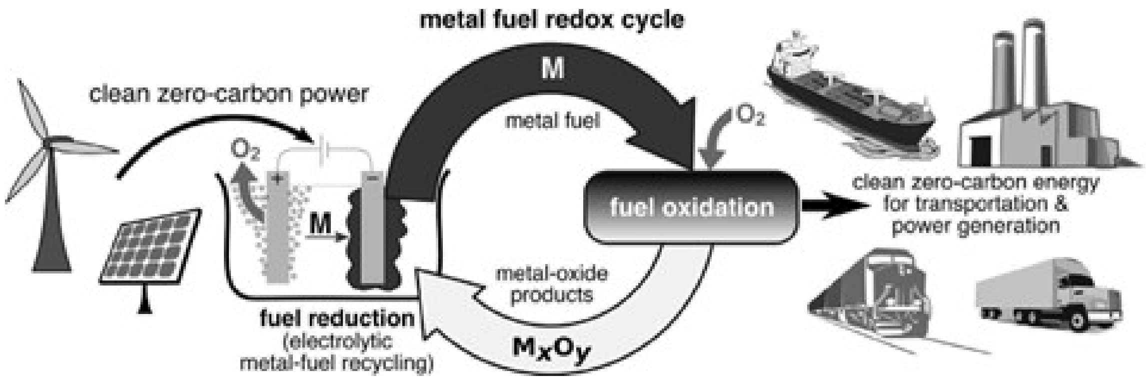

Figure 5: Metal based electro-fuels as secondary energy carriers [5]

- **Metal-based electro-fuels** - including iron, aluminium, magnesium, silicon, and boron. Figure 5 demonstrates the high-level process by which these metal-based electro-fuels can function as recyclable secondary energy carriers, offering a distinctive closed-loop energy storage paradigm
- **Metal hydrides (hydrogen carriers)** - such as MgH_2, AlH_3, $LiBH_4$, and $NaAlH_4$, providing an alternative means of storing and transporting hydrogen in a more dense and stable form than its gaseous state

In the following subsections, a preliminary analysis is conducted to compare the mass energy and volumetric energy densities of these various electro-fuel options in order to understand their viability for marine shipping applications.

1.1.1 High Level Energy Density Analysis

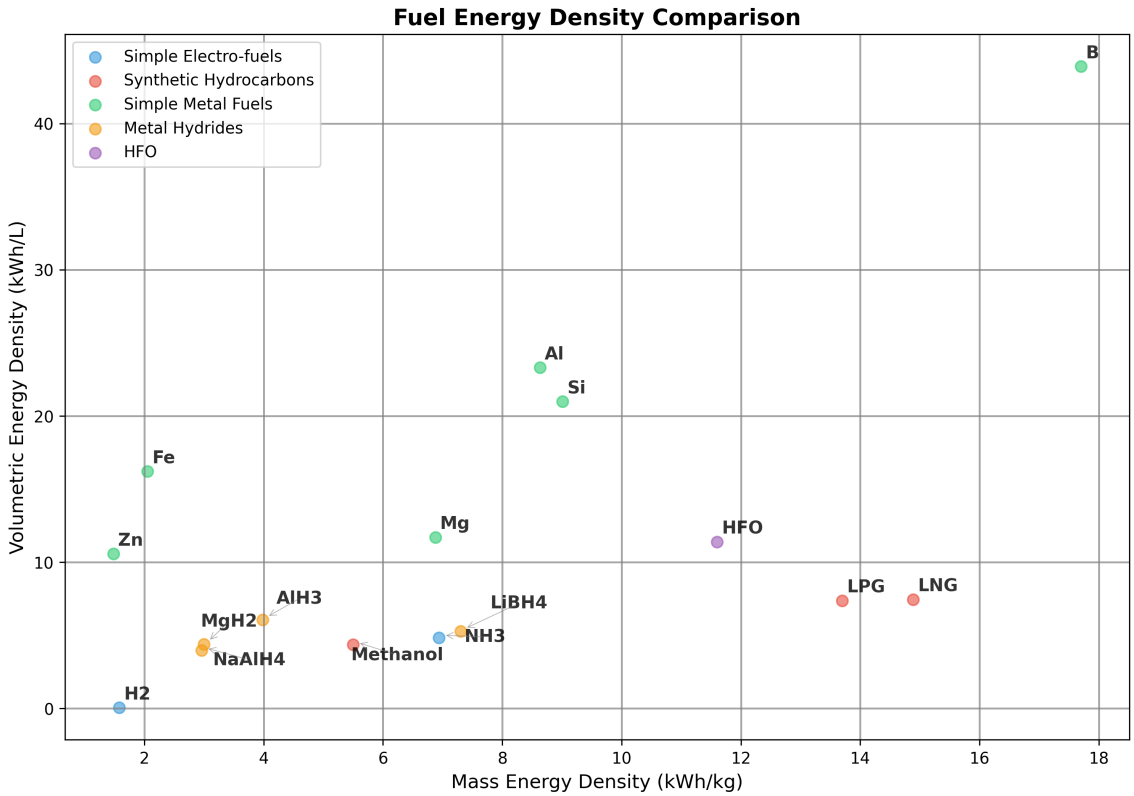

Figure 6: Simplified Energy Density Analysis. Data Analysis can be found in the Appendix. Adapted from [6]

Note: 1) Pressure Cylinder H2 is 25°Celsius 500 bar
2) Liquid NH3 is -33°Celsius 1 bar. Energy needed for cracking for NH3 to H2 is ignored in this table and all subsequent calculations.

Figure 6 presents the fuel energy density calculations for the various electro-fuel options currently under investigation for marine applications. Heavy Fuel Oil (HFO) serves as the reference fuel in these comparisons, as it remains the dominant fuel source for global marine shipping due to its low cost and widespread availability.

Hydrogen, which is being explored as a potential solution for several hard-to-decarbonise sectors including shipping and aviation, requires pressurisation at approximately 500 bar. This compression requirement drastically diminishes the fuel's energy density, presenting significant challenges for practical implementation. Even methanol, which is considered a relatively straightforward drop-in replacement for marine shipping and has garnered substantial support from major shipping companies such as Maersk [19], exhibits significantly lower mass and volumetric energy densities compared to HFO.

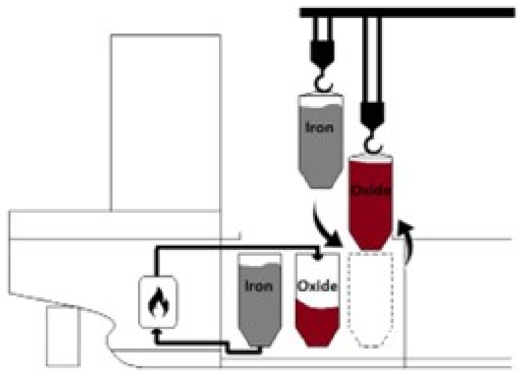

Figure 7: Proposed bunkering procedure for metal fuels (iron powder in this specific case) [7]

As illustrated in Figure 6, metal fuels demonstrate considerable promise in terms of both mass and volumetric energy densities, despite the relatively limited research effort devoted to their development. All metal fuels examined display higher volumetric energy densities than HFO, with boron demonstrating superior performance across all available electro-fuel options and surpassing even HFO itself. However, metal fuels present numerous complications that must be addressed for practical deployment. To make metal fuels economically viable, the metal oxide by-products generated during combustion cannot simply be discharged into the ocean. Instead, these by-products must be retained onboard the vessel and offloaded at ports for subsequent recycling using renewable energy sources, as shown in Fig 5. The bunkering procedure for a metal fuels system is depicted in Figure 7. It is crucial to recognise that energy density calculations which fail to account for the mass and volume of the metal oxide by-products can be highly misleading and do not reflect the true practical performance of these fuel systems.

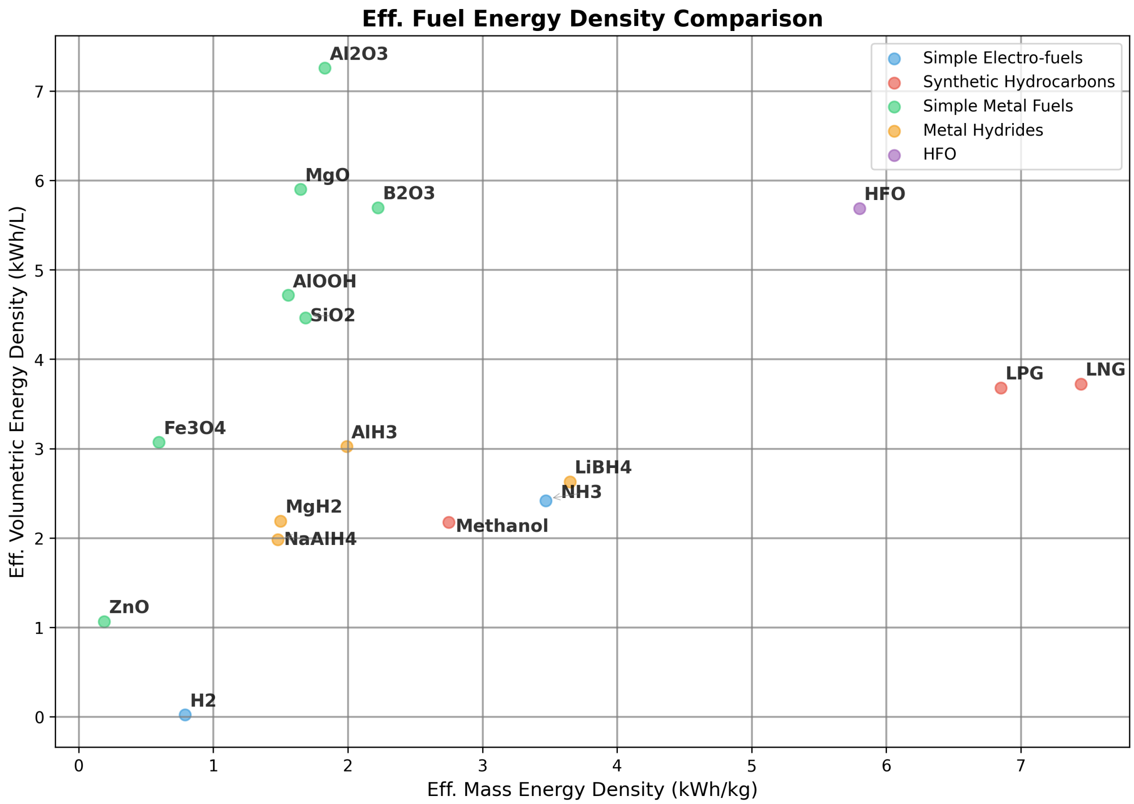

Figure 8: Effective Energy Density Analysis. Data Analysis can be found in the Appendix. Adapted from [6]

Note: 1) Pressure Cylinder H2 is 25°Celsius 500 bar
2) Liquid NH3 is -33°Celsius 1 bar. Energy needed for cracking for NH3 to H2 is ignored in this table and all subsequent calculations.
3) The engine efficiency for hydrogen and hydrocarbon combustion is assumed to be around 50%
4) The engine efficiency for the metal fuels is assumed to be 40%. This number is theortically as no such system currently exists for marine shipping. More information about the metal combustion will be discussed in the following sections.
5) For the metal hydrides, the energy needed to free the stored hydrogen is not considered in this calculation.

1.1.2 Effective Energy Density Analysis

To gain a more comprehensive understanding of the practicality of the different electro-fuel options, an analysis of effective energy densities must be conducted. Effective energy density is defined as the energy density after accounting for engine efficiency, but in the case of metal fuels, it additionally incorporates the weight and volume associated with carrying the metal oxide by-products post-combustion. Figure 8 presents the results from the effective energy density analysis for the various electro-fuel options available. For metal fuels, the effective energy density represents the worst-case scenario of continuously carrying the by-products post-combustion throughout the voyage. In practice, the effective energy density for metal fuels will likely be higher than these calculations suggest, since the by-products can be partially offloaded at ports for collection and subsequent processing at metal reduction facilities.

It should be noted that this is a highly simplified analysis, as the mass and volume of the engines and metal reactors have been deliberately excluded from consideration. Furthermore, there is currently no real-world commercially available marine engine that utilises metal fuels, and therefore an efficiency of approximately 40% has been assumed for these calculations. The complete methodology and detailed calculations for the effective energy density analysis can be found in the Appendix.

As demonstrated in Figure 8, metal fuels remain competitive with the energy density of HFO even after accounting for the metal oxide by-products, particularly with respect to volumetric energy density. Although the mass energy density of the most promising metal fuel candidates, such as aluminium and silicon, remains lower than that of methanol, it is still substantially higher than commercially available electrochemical batteries. The superior volumetric energy densities are of particular significance, given that in practice the metal fuel system will necessitate two sets of storage tanks—one for storing the fuel and another for storing the by-products. This characteristic is also likely to prove advantageous for marine applications where space is at a premium, such as yachts, cruise ships, and container shipping. In later sections, the viability of using aluminium as a marine fuel is discussed in detail, given its promising performance following the effective energy density calculations.

1.2 Aluminium-Water Combustion

Using the energy density analysis from the previous sub-section, aluminium metal emerges as the most promising candidate for use in marine applications. Although it cannot match HFO and other fossil fuels in terms of mass energy density, it demonstrates competitive performance with respect to volumetric energy density. The higher volumetric energy density of aluminium fuel is particularly advantageous for marine applications where space is at a premium, such as yachts, cruise ships, and container ships. Additionally, in practice, the vessel will utilise two storage tanks—one for storing the aluminium powder fuel and another for storing the aluminium oxide by-product, which can be collected later at ports or refuelling stations for recycling.

Aluminium offers several other significant advantages that make it an attractive fuel candidate. It is the third most abundant metal in the Earth's crust, ensuring long-term availability and resource security [1, 20]. Furthermore, aluminium production is already a massive global industry, as the metal's properties make it exceptionally useful across numerous applications. There exists a well-established electrochemical process for producing aluminium from aluminium oxide, known as the Hall-Héroult process. This industrial process can be rendered entirely zero-carbon if the electricity is sourced from renewable energy and the electrolysers make use of inert anodes, thereby eliminating carbon emissions from the production cycle [21].

$$2\,\mathrm{Al} + 3\,\mathrm{H_2O} \longrightarrow \mathrm{Al_2O_3} + 3\,\mathrm{H_2} + 15.152\,\mathrm{MJ/kg{-}Al} \tag{1}$$

$$3\,\mathrm{H_2} + \frac{3}{2}\,\mathrm{O_2} \longrightarrow 3\,\mathrm{H_2O} + 15.840\,\mathrm{MJ/kg{-}Al} \tag{2}$$

Equation 1 demonstrates how aluminium reacts with water to produce heat and hydrogen gas. Equation 2 subsequently shows how this hydrogen gas can then be combusted to produce water and additional heat. Together, these equations reveal that to utilise the full chemical energy potential of the aluminium-water system, both the heat generated from the metal-water reaction and the heat produced from the hydrogen combustion must be harnessed. This metal-water reaction, also known as wet cycle combustion, has already found application in several specialized domains, including ALICE rockets developed for NASA [22] and underwater propulsion applications employed by the American and Russian militaries [23].

1.3 Reactor Design

Overview

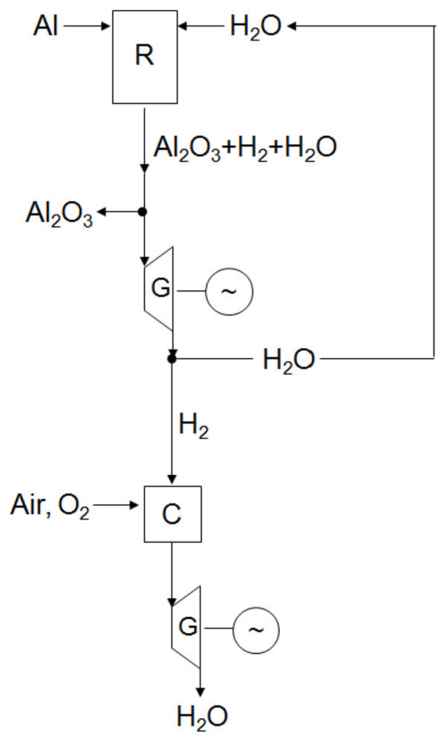

Figure 9: Simplified Overview of Metal-Water Propulsion System (R = metal-water reactor, G = steam generator, C = hydrogen combustion chamber) [8]

The metal-water propulsion system, as illustrated in Fig 9, demonstrates a novel approach to maritime propulsion. In this system, seawater from the ocean is mixed with aluminium powder from the fuel tank within a specialized metal-water reactor. The resulting reaction generates three key outputs: hydrogen, thermal heat, and aluminium oxide by-product, with the latter being separated into a dedicated storage tank. The system harnesses energy through two pathways: the thermal heat is utilized to drive a steam engine, while the produced hydrogen can be combusted in a separate chamber to generate high-temperature steam for powering an additional steam engine.

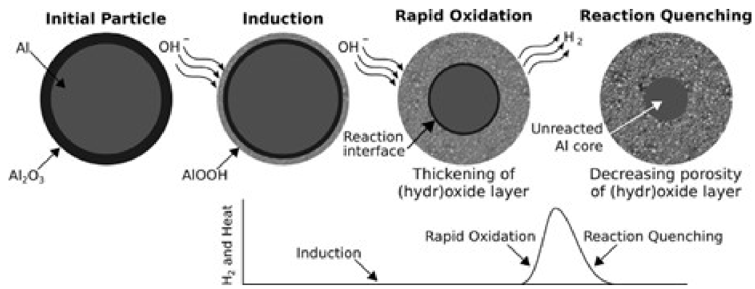

Figure 10: Schematic of the three reaction stages of aluminium with water at low temperatures, including a sketch of the initial dry particle for reference. Also sketched is the characteristic hydrogen-production curve showing the induction, rapid oxidation, and quenching stages [9]

Fig 10 illustrates the reaction pathway for the low temperature aluminium-water reaction, depicting an aluminium particle encased by a thin, inert aluminium oxide coating that must be overcome to facilitate metal-water oxidation. The metal-water reactor design requires careful optimization to achieve appropriate reaction rates for marine propulsion applications, while simultaneously maximizing hydrogen yield to enhance both the efficiency and mass energy density of the aluminium fuel.

The reaction rate and hydrogen yield can be enhanced through:

- Increased temperature and/or pressure conditions
- Reduced aluminium powder particle size
- Reduced aluminium powder to water ratio
- Implementation of various catalysts (detailed in following sub-section) [9, 8, 24]

1.3.1 Low-Temp vs High-Temp Metal-Water Reactor

Parameter	LT-MWR	HT-MWR
Particle Size	Nano-sized particles	Micron-sized particles
Catalysts	Range of special alloys (lithium, gallium, mercury, etc.)	No catalysts
Temperature and Pressure	Below 120°C (can operate at room temperature depending on catalyst)	250–400°C and 15–25 MPa
Metal By-product	$Al(OH)_3$ or AlOOH	AlOOH or Al_2O_3
Worst Case Mass Energy Density (kWh/kg)	0.60 or 0.78	1.55 or 1.82
Worst Case Volumetric Energy Density (kWh/L)	1.44 or 2.35	4.70 or 7.23
Thermal Heat Utilization	Difficult due to low temperature	Possible with simple steam turbines
Fuel Production Costs	Higher (smaller particles and ball milling alloys)	Lower (larger particles and low catalysts)
Round-trip Energy Efficiency	11–13% (if no heat is utilized)	23–25%
Fuel Transport Costs	Higher (exothermic reaction with water at room temperature)	Lower (mostly inert due to Al_2O_3 layer at room temperature)
Fuel Handling Safety	Lower	Higher
Reactor Manufacturing Costs	Lower	Higher (needs to withstand high temperature and pressure)
Reactor Start-up Time	Lower (ability to load follow)	15–30 minutes (better for baseloads)

Table 1: Comparison of Low Temperature Metal-Water Reactors (LT-MWR) and High Temperature Metal-Water Reactors (HT-MWR)

1.4 Economics of Aluminium Fuel

2 Research Questions

3 Methodology

4 Proposed Project Timeline

5 References

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